

Application checklist

What to have ready for every resource in the Help the Homeless guide. Built at the Claude Impact Lab, Birmingham, August 28, 2026.

READ THIS FIRST. Every item below comes from each organization's own public site, verified on 2026-08-28, and nothing more. Requirements change and vary by program, so confirm with each agency before you gather documents. Where a site publishes no checklist, this page says so instead of guessing. This is a printable takeaway from a demo tool, not legal, medical, or benefits advice, and nothing in it is a live feed. No door in the call-first list requires you to arrive with a medical diagnosis. Where a program's eligibility runs on one, its entry says so and names who makes that decision.

Applications to start

These take time. Starting them early is part of setting the person up to succeed.

Alabama Medicaid

State health coverage. Alabama did not expand Medicaid so most single adults qualify only through disability or as a very-low-income parent. File the disability claim first and Medicaid can follow.

How to apply or reach them: Apply online at medicaid.alabama.gov or turn the application in to the right office. Recipient Call Center (800) 362-1504.

Have ready:

- ☐ Proof of income
- ☐ Every Medicaid program has its own requirements and all of them have income requirements. Ask which program fits before gathering more.

Medical diagnosis: A disability decision is required for the disability route and it comes from Social Security, not from the family and not from a doctor's note alone. Alabama Medicaid's own page says some disabled people qualify when they qualify for SSI, and SSI's medical decision runs through Social Security's process (medicaid.alabama.gov E&D page, verified 2026-08-28).

Source: medicaid.alabama.gov/content/3.0_Apply/ · verified 2026-08-28

Legal Services Alabama

Free civil legal help including eviction defense and benefits appeals.

How to apply or reach them: Apply online through their site or call 866-456-4995, Monday through Friday 8:30 to 4:30.

Have ready:

- ☐ Expect income questions. They serve low-income Alabamians.
- ☐ Their site does not publish a document checklist. Ask at intake.

Source: legalservicesalabama.org · verified 2026-08-28

Social Security disability

SSI and SSDI income for people whose conditions keep them from working. Decisions take months so start now.

How to apply or reach them: Apply at ssa.gov/apply. SSDI needs a disability or blindness plus enough work history. SSI is for people who are blind or have a disability and find it hard to pay for essentials.

Have ready:

- ☐ Their site does not publish one document checklist on the pages we verified. Ask what they need when you apply.

Medical diagnosis: A medical decision is required and the family does not make it. Social Security sends the application to the state Disability Determination Services office, and that office decides about the medical condition. A note from a family doctor alone does not decide it, so have the names of the doctors and clinics who have treated your person ready when asked (ssa.gov/benefits/disability/qualify.html, verified 2026-08-28).

Source: www.ssa.gov/apply · verified 2026-08-28

Alabama DHR Food Assistance

Food assistance through SNAP once called Food Stamps run by the Alabama Department of Human Resources.

How to apply or reach them: Apply online, by mail, fax, or in person in the county where you live. Decision within 30 days, or 7 days expedited with little or no income.

Have ready:

- ☐ Proof of income
- ☐ Current proof of rent or mortgage expenses
- ☐ Proof of child care expenses
- ☐ Social Security numbers for everyone in the household
- ☐ Proof of child support paid to someone outside the household

Medical diagnosis: No medical diagnosis is needed to apply.

Source: dhr.alabama.gov/food-assistance/food-assistance-division-frequently-asked-questions/ · verified 2026-08-28

HUD rental assistance

Federal rental help including public housing and Housing Choice Vouchers through local housing agencies. Waiting lists open and close so ask your housing agency which lists are open now.

How to apply or reach them: Apply through your local public housing agency. Find yours through [hud.gov](https://www.hud.gov). Each agency sets its own paperwork.

Have ready:

- ☐ Income paperwork such as pay stubs and bank information
- ☐ Paperwork for other assistance such as SSI or SNAP
- ☐ Proof of citizenship and Social Security cards
- ☐ The head of household needs a valid Social Security number

Source: www.hud.gov/helping-americans/housing-choice-vouchers-tenants · verified 2026-08-28

Call first, no application needed

These doors open with a phone call or a visit to the site.

988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline

24/7 crisis line that also takes calls from worried family members.

How to apply or reach them: Call or text 988. No application and no paperwork.

Have ready:

- ☐ Nothing. Just call.

Source: 988lifeline.org · verified 2026-08-28

Crisis Center Birmingham

Local 988 crisis center for the Birmingham area and home of the Recovery Resource Center.

How to apply or reach them: Call or use the contact page on their site. No application published.

Have ready:

- ☐ Nothing required to call.

Source: www.crisiscenterbham.org · verified 2026-08-28

JBS Mental Health Authority

Community mental health authority for Jefferson Blount and St. Clair counties with a crisis center and a Jefferson County Probate Court program.

How to apply or reach them: Intake starts through their contact page. Ask about service area and intake requirements when you call.

Have ready:

- ☐ Ask when you call. Their site does not publish a checklist.

Medical diagnosis: No diagnosis is needed to call. Ask when you call whether the program you need requires one and who does that assessment.

Source: jbsmentalhealth.com · verified 2026-08-28

211 Connects Alabama

Free 24/7 statewide referral line for food housing health care and more.

How to apply or reach them: Dial 2-1-1 or text your ZIP code to 898-211. No application.

Have ready:

- ☐ Nothing. The referral line is free.

Source: www.211connectsalabama.org · verified 2026-08-28

FindTreatment.gov

Federal locator for licensed mental health and substance use treatment including programs for both together.

How to apply or reach them: Search the locator free, no sign-up. Each treatment program sets its own intake.

Have ready:

- ☐ Ask each program what to bring. The locator itself needs nothing.

Medical diagnosis: No diagnosis is needed to search or to call a program. Each program sets its own intake so ask whether it requires a referral or an assessment and who performs it.

Source: findtreatment.gov · verified 2026-08-28

Alabama Department of Mental Health

State authority over public mental health and substance use services in Alabama.

How to apply or reach them: Not an application door. The state authority over public mental health and substance use services, useful for finding and verifying licensed providers.

Have ready:

- ☐ Nothing. Use it to check providers.

Source: mh.alabama.gov · verified 2026-08-28

One Roof

Coordinated Entry lead for the greater Birmingham area and the front door to shelter and housing help.

How to apply or reach them: Coordinated Entry intake starts by contacting One Roof. Their site does not publish an intake checklist.

Have ready:

- ☐ Ask what intake needs when you reach them.

Source: www.oneroofonline.org · verified 2026-08-28

NAMI Alabama

Family education and support groups for mental illness including support for families whose person refuses help.

How to apply or reach them: Support groups are free. Contact through the site to find a group. No application.

Have ready:

☐ Nothing. Come as you are.

Medical diagnosis: No diagnosis is needed. Family groups are for the family and no paperwork about your person is asked for.

Source: namialabama.org · verified 2026-08-28

In a crisis right now: call or text **988**. For referrals to food, housing, and health care: dial **2-1-1** or text your ZIP to **898-211**. If anyone is in danger, call **911**.

Help the Homeless · Team 4B · github.com/mhancock537/confirm-first-handoff · This page collects nothing and sends nothing. No name or personal detail appears on it.